

PhD Mental Preparation Watchlist

A Curated & Ordered Video Guide for CS PhD Students Targeting Tenure-Track Careers

This document organizes 18 videos into 6 phases — designed to be watched in order. Each phase builds on the previous one: first you understand the landscape, then you build the mindset, then the skills, then the strategy, then execution, and finally sustainability. All links are clickable.

Prepared for: Incoming CS PhD Student, Northern Illinois University (Fall 2026)

Goal: Tenure-Track Faculty or Top-Tier Research Scientist Position

PHASE 1: UNDERSTAND WHAT YOU'RE GETTING INTO

Watch these first to calibrate your expectations. Go in with eyes wide open.

1

PhD in 2026: Why Most Students Don't Know What They're Getting Into

Why watch this: Start here. This gives you the raw, unfiltered reality of what a PhD actually looks like in 2026 — the funding landscape, the mental toll, the time commitment. You need to know the battlefield before you step onto it.

<https://youtu.be/cAGebL4JVam?si=SUDCXO7nIWaBN4en>

Action tip: Take notes on anything that surprises you — those are your blind spots.

2

What They Don't Tell You About PhDs (Until You're Trapped)

Why watch this: Complements Video #1 with the hidden costs and unspoken realities. The 'trapped' framing is deliberate — knowing these pitfalls now means you can design escape routes before you ever need them.

https://youtu.be/JBEwRRwQFdA?si=oQ-E1xexFtg3_PPM

Action tip: Identify which traps are most relevant to your situation at NIU specifically.

3

What I Wish I Knew About Money When I Was in Graduate School

Why watch this: Financial stress is the #1 silent PhD killer. Understanding stipend management, tax implications, and financial planning now prevents money from derailing your research later. You'll be on a grad student budget for 5+ years — plan for it.

<https://youtu.be/3uqKx4uAUZ4?si=TsdT4ayRTogAVk-W>

Action tip: Set up a budget framework before Fall 2026 starts.

PHASE 2: BUILD THE RIGHT MINDSET FOR RESEARCH

These reshape how you think about research itself — essential before you start doing it.

4

Uri Alon: Why Truly Innovative Science Demands a Leap into the Unknown

Why watch this: The single most important mindset video for any researcher. Alon's concept of 'the cloud' — that terrifying space where nothing works and you feel like a failure — is something you WILL experience. Knowing it's normal, and even necessary, changes everything. This is a TED Talk by a systems biology professor who uses improv theater to teach resilience.

<https://youtu.be/F1U26PLiXjM?si=ECQUn8ZCexNgDcT->

Action tip: Remember 'the cloud' when your first research direction hits a dead end (it will).

5

What Elite PhD Students Do Differently (It's Surprisingly Simple)

Why watch this: You're competing against CMU, UT Austin, and Stanford students. This video reveals the habits and mindset shifts that separate productive PhD students from struggling ones. The 'surprisingly simple' part is key — it's not about being smarter, it's about being more deliberate.

<https://youtu.be/6msyhytLRiE?si=GWZF8xrZXIFcSK51>

Action tip: Pick the 2-3 habits most actionable for you and implement them from Week 1.

6

6 PhD Habits That Will Save You Years of Struggle

Why watch this: Concrete, battle-tested habit systems from someone who's been through it. At a non-top-tier program, you cannot afford to lose years to bad habits that students at elite schools can sometimes recover from due to institutional momentum. Every semester counts.

https://youtu.be/GRkhG7L8AoM?si=IS_hi_lyFLEWRNut

Action tip: Build these habits during summer 2026, before classes even start.

PHASE 3: MASTER THE CORE RESEARCH SKILLS

Paper reading and paper writing are the two fundamental skills of your PhD. Learn the systems.

7

How to Read a Paper Efficiently (By Prof. Pete Carr)

Why watch this: You'll read hundreds of papers during your PhD. Reading inefficiently means falling behind on the literature, missing key insights, and wasting hours per paper. Prof. Carr's algorithm turns paper reading from a chore into a systematic skill. This is non-negotiable before your first literature review.

<https://youtu.be/leaD0ZaUJ3Y?si=4FUdc7p9ZD1Inij4>

Action tip: Practice this method on 5 papers in your target research area this summer.

8

How to Write a Paper in a Weekend (By Prof. Pete Carr)

Why watch this: Publications at top venues are your currency for the tenure-track market. This isn't about rushing — it's about having a writing system so you never stare at a blank page. Karpathy and every successful CS PhD will tell you: the students who publish are the ones with a process, not just talent.

<https://youtu.be/UY7sVKJPTMA?si=oPtUWliPu3QvKsV->

Action tip: Watch this again right before writing your first paper draft.

PHASE 4: STRATEGIC PhD PREPARATION

Tactical videos on how to prepare and what to do in your first weeks/months.

9

How to Prepare for a PhD | Clever Prep!

Why watch this: Actionable pre-PhD checklist. You still have months before Fall 2026 — this tells you exactly what to do with that time. Preparation done now compounds over the entire 5-year PhD timeline.

<https://youtu.be/4KnoZQyGhhY?si=oT85P09bPwqHZpOY>

Action tip: Create a personal checklist from this video and start checking items off.

10

Before a PhD — 5 Secrets for Starting Strong!

Why watch this: Complements Video #9 with less obvious preparation strategies — the 'secrets' framing means these are things most incoming students overlook. Combined with the previous video, you'll arrive at NIU more prepared than 90% of new PhD students anywhere.

https://youtu.be/sdp3WeJi-5Q?si=i4MSiprRaMp_mWu1

Action tip: Focus on the secrets related to advisor relationships and research direction.

11

PhD Student Advice — 15 Things I Wish I Knew Before Starting a PhD

Why watch this: Wisdom from hindsight. Each of these 15 points represents a mistake someone else made so you don't have to. Pay special attention to advice about time management and advisor communication — these are the areas where NIU students can gain an edge through discipline.

<https://youtu.be/te2Ae-OWE5E?si=K-CirmCelDou6jl2>

Action tip: Rank these 15 points by personal relevance and address your top 5.

PHASE 5: DOMINATE YOUR FIRST YEAR

Re-watch these during your first semester. Year 1 sets the trajectory for everything.

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First Year PhD Student Advice — 20 Things to Do Early in Your PhD

Why watch this: A dense, practical list of early actions. The first 3-6 months determine your advisor relationship, your research direction, and your productivity systems. Treat this as your onboarding manual.

<https://youtu.be/JNR08AQykXE?si=ZcDIHq9cqPnamuma>

Action tip: Bookmark this and revisit it at the end of each month during Year 1.

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First Year PhD — 5 Tips to Help You Succeed!

Why watch this: Focused and concise — 5 high-impact tips rather than an overwhelming list. Good for when you're in the thick of coursework and need quick, actionable reminders.

<https://youtu.be/ius0NbvrB7A?si=vz0po70J3McCoBVz>

Action tip: Pin these 5 tips somewhere you see daily (desk, phone wallpaper, sticky note).

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PhD First Year Tips! DOMINATE Your First Year!

Why watch this: The aggressive tone matches your competitive mindset. This video is about winning Year 1, not just surviving it. At NIU, dominating Year 1 means: passing quals on the first attempt, identifying your research niche, and getting your first submission pipeline going.

<https://youtu.be/HXNyA3kmGKQ?si=PcJDf6dtkg51xYBM>

Action tip: Set a Year 1 goal: submit at least one paper to a top venue by month 10.

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PhD First Year Advice — 20 Things I Wish I Knew When I Started

Why watch this: Another comprehensive first-year guide from a different perspective. Cross-referencing multiple first-year advice videos helps you identify the recurring themes — those are the universal truths of PhD Year 1.

<https://youtu.be/BNXMehMjx2w?si=U2JhIT6klLBpckrP>

Action tip: Note which advice overlaps with Videos #12-14 — those are the non-negotiables.

PHASE 6: PROTECT YOUR MENTAL HEALTH & SUSTAIN PERFORMANCE

The PhD is a 5-year marathon. These keep you running without burning out.

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How to Ruin Your Mental Health as a PhD Student

Why watch this: Reverse psychology format — shows you what to avoid. PhD mental health struggles are extremely common, and students at non-top-tier schools can face additional isolation and imposter syndrome. Knowing the warning signs means you can intervene early.

<https://youtu.be/gLdFzZ4LpPo?si=faQkqPia9wVx53Or>

Action tip: Share this with a trusted friend or partner who can hold you accountable.

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Focus Toolkit: Tools to Improve Your Focus & Concentration (Huberman Lab)

Why watch this: Neuroscience-backed protocols for deep work. Your PhD output = quality of focus x hours spent. Huberman's 90-minute ultradian cycle framework, cold exposure protocols, and supplement recommendations are evidence-based ways to get more out of every research session. This is your competitive edge at the biological level.

<https://www.hubermanlab.com/episode/focus-toolkit-tools-to-improve-your-focus-and-concentration>

Action tip: Experiment with 2-3 protocols this summer and find what works for your body.

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8

Tools for Improving Productivity | Dr. Cal Newport & Dr. Andrew Huberman

Why watch this: Cal Newport literally wrote the book on Deep Work. Combined with Huberman's neuroscience lens, this conversation gives you both the systems (Newport) and the biology (Huberman) of sustained high-level cognitive output. PhD research is deep work — optimize for it.

<https://youtu.be/-8nOPy9UFDI?si=yuLTcLs3JoVxVMb5>

Action tip: Implement Newport's time-blocking method for your research hours from Day 1.

Remember: The tenure-track market is paper-blind, not school-blind. A hiring committee member sees your publications, your reference letters, and your research vision — not your university's ranking. Start building that CV from Day 1.

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